Constellations

By Nick Payne

Note: Marianne works at Sussex University, indicating that both characters could/should be performed with British accents.

MARIANNE: **(Pg 9-12)** Do you know why it's impossible to lick the tips of your elbows? They hold the secret to immortality, so if you could lick them, there's a chance you'd be able to live forever. But if everyone did it, then there'd be chaos. Because you can't just go on living and living and living. . . Try it. Your elbows, try licking them. *(Marianne attempts to lick her elbows, demonstrating the difficulty. Roland, initially hesitant, also attempts to lick his elbows.)*

ROLAND: See what you mean. I'm Roland.

MARIANNE: Marianne.

ROLAND: So what do you, what do you do? For a living.

MARIANNE: I work at Sussex University. **(Pg 21)** Quantum cosmology. **(Pg 12)** Yourself?

ROLAND: I'm a beekeeper.

MARIANNE: Really?

ROLAND: Yeah, yeah. I'm really a beekeeper.

MARIANNE: I [absolutely] love honey.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Marianne, a physicist, and Roland, a beekeeper, meet at a party. They hit it off and their relationship blossoms.*
ACTRESS: *It's incredible to be in love – but it's even more incredible when that love turns into something more . . .*
TOGETHER: *Commitment . . . Constellations by Nick Payne*

MARIANNE: **(Pg 48-49)** This is a surprise. It's the middle of the afternoon.

ROLAND: Are you busy? **. . .** There's something I'd like to say. To you. *(Roland takes a piece of A4 paper from a pocket and nervously reads.)* There are three different kinds of bees. The

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drones, the workers and a single, solitary queen. The workers are all women. Their job is to forage for honey, pollen, etcetera. Their lifespan is potentially anywhere between five weeks and six months. And then they die. Drones exist solely to have sex with the queen. Each hive tends to have around a hundred drones. Honeybees have an unfailing clarity of purpose. Their lives are often intensely short. If only our existence were that simple. If only we could understand why it is that we're here and what it is that we're meant to spend our lives doing. I am uncertain when it comes to a great many things. But there is now one thing I am defiantly certain of. *(Roland folds up the piece of paper, puts it back in his pocket and - from another pocket - takes out a small black box.)*

MARIANNE: Roland, please. *(Roland kneels and opens the small black box.)* Roland, get up, come on.

ROLAND: Marianne Aubele, will you marry me? *(Beat -- Roland slowly gets to his feet)*

MARIANNE: Roland, we talked about this . . . *(she is hesitant, but then quickly makes up her mind)* **(Pg 52)** Okay

ROLAND: *(Astounded)* Really?

MARIANNE: *(giggling and excited)* Yeah, really. *(Marianne kisses Roland. Roland slides the engagement ring on to the appropriate finger. Marianne kisses Roland again.)*

TRANSITION

ACTOR: *And so marital bliss descended on the happy couple.*
ACTRESS: *For a few years they shared everything. An apartment, meals, clothes . . .*
ACTOR: *Until one day, Marianne started having headaches and other unexplained symptoms. She decided to go to her doctor for a routine check-up.*
ACTRESS: *It was then that the Constellations shifted . . .*

Marianne enters - The spark has gone out of her eyes and she appears extremely tired and stunned. Roland immediately recognizes from her appearance that something is drastically wrong. Marianne's speech is obviously impaired. She searches for the right word for nouns especially.

ROLAND: **(Pg 54)** -How bad is it? Mary

MARIANNE: It's pretty bad. They said being under forty might help, but –

ROLAND: Mary, how bad is pretty bad?

MARIANNE: I'm not sure I want to talk about it right away. I'm not sure I ***can*** talk about it.

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ROLAND: Do you want something to drink, do you want some water?

MARIANNE: No thank you. . . *(Beat)* He said, I think, something like a third, a third of people live for a year. **(Pg 59)** It's called a glioblastoma multiforme. **(Pg 56)** He said I might have trouble selecting the right words. **(Pg 59)** Which is why I've been having trouble . . .

ROLAND: Speaking.

MARIANNE: **(Pg 55-56)** He said they can operate. Try and remove it, remove as much of it as they can. Then they said radiotherapy but if I'm too weak for radiotherapy, they said chemo. . . . It's right at the front.

ROLAND: The front?

MARIANNE: It's all over the frontal lobe. *(gesturing to her forehead)*

ROLAND: I don't know what that means.

MARIANNE: He said I should expect seizures.

ROLAND: Jesus Christ.

MARIANNE: It's palliative. Whatever they do. It's not - They can't.

ROLAND: Okay.

MARIANNE: They said this is it.

ROLAND: Okay.

MARIANNE: This is it, they said.

ROLAND: Okay. Okay. . . I would have come with you if you'd told me, you know. I would've cancelled –

MARIANNE: I know.

TRANSITION

ACTOR: *Cancer – One of the constellations of the zodiac*
ACTRESS: *Glioblastoma multiforme is the most aggressive type of brain cancer.*
ACTOR: *People suffering from this form of cancer live on average less than 15 months, even with radiation and chemotherapy treatments.*
ACTRESS: *Symptoms progress rapidly as the brain literally begins to die.*
ACTOR: *Blurred vision, vomiting, loss of appetite and decreased ability to read, write and speak . . . Until . . .*

MARIANNE: **(Pg 70-71)** Roland, I don't think that I can go back to work.

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ROLAND: You've told them then?

MARIANNE: Not yet.

ROLAND: So what about part-time?

MARIANNE: I don't know the point. . . . Either I'm walking *(she means working, but can't find the right word)* or I'm . . . *(She tries again)* Either I'm . . . . walker. *(Gives up on the word working)* I either do it or I don't. Scares me.

ROLAND: Work?

MARIANNE: Stopping.

ROLAND: Stopping work scares you?

MARIANNE: What will I do?

ROLAND: We'll go away. We can do whatever we want.

MARIANNE: I don't - I don't -

ROLAND: I mean it.

MARIANNE: I . . . . I don't. We can't. I have to . . . have to . . . make a *(can't find the word "decision")* I have to have a choice . . . Control. *(Marianne begins using sign language and Roland voices her words aloud. An occasional word or phase can be voiced together by both Marianne and Roland)*

MARIANNE: **(Pg 68-69)** I keep thinking of Mum. Before she died.

ROLAND: Right.

MARIANNE: When she said she didn't want any more food. Do you remember?

ROLAND: I'm not sure we ever really talked about it?

MARIANNE: She said she wanted them to stop the IV, did we talk about that? *(confused)*

ROLAND: I think maybe we did yeah.

MARIANNE: They asked me to leave. I went back the next day and she was starting to look like a ghost. It takes an enormous amount of strength. When you're like that. To keep going. I'm not sure I have it.

ROLAND: You don't know. You don't know that.

MARIANNE: Sinking feeling. Mum wasn't scared of dying, she was scared of being kept alive. You know? *(Marianne goes to cry, but stops herself)*

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TRANSITION

ACTOR: *And Marianne faced a similar fear. Because the rest of her body was young and healthy, she was worried that life support efforts would leave her in a vegetative state; wasting away for weeks or even months.*

ACTRESS: *Despite radiation and chemotherapy treatments, Marianne was dying. Her research skills couldn't find a cure . . . but they did provide her with an option.*

TOGETHER: *Death with dignity*

MARIANNE: **(Pg 64-67)** *(severe struggling with her words)* I think I'd like to go abroad. I'm not . . . I'm not sure how much of a difference the chemo is really making.

ROLAND: D'you mean you're not sure or they're not sure?

MARIANNE: I mean me. I mean I'm not sure.

ROLAND: Why? What aren't you sure about?

MARIANNE: It's ganging . . . It's . . . It's . . . *(can't find the words anymore and resorts back to sign language. Roland voices this passage and Marianne is silent, we can see the strong emotions in her facial expressions)* I was on the train and I was coming home. A group of men got on. A group of thirty-year-old men. They started, they started winding me up. I put my laptop in my bag and I tried to move to a different seat. But they blocked me, they wouldn't let me past. I couldn't speak. I couldn't find the right words and they started laughing. They howled with laughter. I started to cry and finally one of them said that's enough.

ROLAND: You should have said, you should have told me.

MARIANNE: I went on to campus. *(in sign language only)*

ROLAND: What do you mean ["I went on to campus"], what for?

MARIANNE: *(she struggles to speak these words aloud)* To have lunch with Melisa. I had a seizure.

ROLAND: What? When? Mary.

MARIANNE: A couple of weeks ago. *(in sign language only)*

ROLAND: A couple of weeks ago? *(Marianne nods)* Why didn't you tell me?

MARIANNE: *(she struggles to speak these words aloud)* It's the words, Roland. It's exhibit *(can't find the word for "exhausting")* It's ex . . . . It's becoming more and more tiring.

ROLAND: You mean speaking to me, the two of us, is tiring, or you mean everything?

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MARIANNE: *(aloud)* Everything.

ROLAND: I didn't realise. . . I'm sorry. . . I don't know what to do . . . So when you say abroad, you mean **abroad** and not come back? *(Marianne nods, we see the resignation in her face)*

ROLAND: How does it work?

MARIANNE: You become a member. *(sign language only)*

ROLAND: A member?

MARIANNE: *(Marianne signs and Roland voices)* Pay some money.

ROLAND: Then what?

MARIANNE: *(Marianne signs and Roland voices)* If you're serious you write to them. Outline why they ought to be taking you seriously.

ROLAND: And if they do?

MARIANNE: *(Marianne again tries to speak aloud)* You meet someone. . . . Out there. You . . . You . . . You have to meet them a couple of times.

ROLAND: Then what?

MARIANNE: *(aloud)* Then it's up to you.

ROLAND: How do they do it, how does it work?

MARIANNE: *(aloud with growing frustration)* They use something called a Bar Abar . . . A . . . A

ROLAND: It's okay.

MARIANNE: *(aloud)* They mix it with water.

ROLAND: *(angry, sad, exasperated)* I don't really know what to say -- I want to know what to say to you.

MARIANNE: *(aloud)* A lot of people apparently never go through with it. A lot of people, once they've been given the green night *(searching for the word "light") . . .* Night . . . Once they've . . . *(she gives up, frustrated – may pound her head or pull her hair)*

ROLAND: It's okay.

MARIANNE: *(reverts to signing as Roland voices)* They're, they're happy enough knowing it's there . . . . *(Marianne speaks aloud)* Safety net. For a lot of people.

ROLAND: And is that how you're feeling about it?

MARIANNE: I don't know. *(Beat, then Marianne slowly nods. Beat)* **(pg 68-70)** I'm so tired, Roland. It's not just the speaking. Reading. I'm having trouble - Numbers, words, on the page. I know

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the word . . . I know the word. But I don't know the letters. None of the letters seem right.

(Gets stuck on the word "reading" again) Rea . . . Rea . . . Rea

ROLAND: You don't need to finish. I think I know what you're trying to say.

MARIANNE: *(in anguish)* How? . . . How can you know what I'm trying to say? . . . Mmm . . . . Most of the time I don't even know what I'm trying to say.

(Both characters exit – scene change) – In silent pantomime we should see Marianne enter, and retrieve the medicine she's gotten to end her own life. She mixes it with water, perhaps pens a note to Roland and then drinks it. She should sit as the medicine takes affect and we should see her pass from life. Roland enters – finds Marianne's lifeless form on the floor and reacts. (Both characters exit)

Roland re-enters, perhaps silently reading the note left for him by Marianne, then focuses in the distance as if he can hear Marianne's voice)

MARIANNE: **(Pg 9)** *(only a voice off-stage, in Roland's memory-she speaks clearly and there is great energy in her voice)* Do you know why it's impossible to lick the tips of your elbows? They hold the secret to immortality, so if you could lick them, there's a chance you'd be able to live forever. But if everyone did it, then there'd be chaos. Because you can't just go on living and living and living. Try it. Your elbows, try licking them.

ROLAND: [I] See what you mean. . . . *(Roland breaks down to tears)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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NOTE: A good place to start learning American Sign Language is http://lifeprint.com/ - Actresses playing the role of Marianne will need assistance in your local area to perfect the signing portion of this duo.

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